

Part V

Beyond Dancing in the Gallery

The final case studies of the book continue along the interwoven paths of dance and visual art forms, following artists from non-dance to post-dance, and from disciplinarity to a-disciplinarity. Part V opens with Agatha Gothe-Snape, an artist committed to working with choreography in the expanded field of contemporary art, and closes with Latai Taumoepeau, whose expanded field reaches paradigms beyond the horizons of this project through its incorporation of First Nations knowledges and practices. These case studies frame Chapter 8 which addresses a reactionary turn back to the dancing body by some of the central protagonists in the Western theater dance debates surrounding non-dance. The work of Gothe-Snape emerges from a community of practice with dancer-peers, echoing the innovations of second-wave artists such as Robert Rauschenberg. Improvisation, collectivity, care, and mediality are combined with a post-conceptual position that is in critical dialogue with the male-dominated narratives of the twentieth century. In Chapter 8, the persistence of dance is argued for within the context of a *post-* model of contemporary art. Following a meeting ground for dance and visual art in (variations on) the conceptual (1960s and later in the 1990s), a very recent and widespread return to the

materiality of art has turned the focus within contemporary dance toward the activity of dancing, which has involved honoring the work of the dancer through a greater understanding of their labor. This is shown to be at the heart of the visual arts' renewed interest in dance, alongside and in dialogue with the notion of choreographic objects. The emergent activity of dance as a contemporary art medium shares some characteristics with the post-conceptual (via Peter Osborne)—art which is transdisciplinary and telescopic, temporally expansive and unhinged from specific iterations, yet deeply self-aware of the contemporaneous Page 190 → context, institutional frames, and its debts to the past. Taumoepeau, Case Study 11, closes the book with an art practice that exceeds the limitations of the methodology chosen for this book which rests on paradigms of contemporary art and contemporary dance as they have been theorized by mostly Australian, American, and European artists, curators, and theorists. This reveals layers of inclusion and exclusion that complicate the advocacy-driven thrust of this project and opens onto a future for dance as a contemporary art practice that is as intersectional as it is intermedial.

Case Study 10

Agatha Gothe-Snape—Art as Gesture

Agatha Gothe-Snape is a Sydney-based artist who has worked consistently with dance artists as collaborators, engaged with choreographic and performance strategies and practices, and included dancing in some of her works as one component among many (including light, vocalization, sound, PowerPoint, text, lectures, workshops, color, projection, found video . . .). She describes this as “dancing around the territory of choreography,” and artworks such as those discussed here, *Rhetorical Chorus* (2017) and *Three Ways to Enter and Exit* (2011), demonstrate how dance can be a powerful medium for materialization within the post-conceptual, a condition that might frame Gothe-Snape’s larger body of work.¹ Such works also model an alternative to dancing in the gallery as it has been discussed in the work of Sarah Michelson, Meg Stuart, Adam Linder, Maria Hassabi, Shelley Lasica, and others through their acute interdisciplinarity. They are also an exception among other Australian artists such as Justene Williams, Sally Smart, and David Rosetzky who also work with dancers in a mix of media. Like Robert Rauschenberg, Gothe-Snape is embedded in social and professional contexts with dance artists, and she also trained in performance early in her professional development.² She engages with improvisation in her method, describing how she makes “new discoveries in the act of doing” and, like Lasica, “the context and viewer experience is the generative principle.”³

Dance as an art form offers Gothe-Snape a template for collaboration as it did for Rauschenberg; both artists seem to draw inspiration from its collective nature discussed in Chapter 2 where I quoted Jennifer Lacey: “dance is about people spending time together, thinking by behaving, and modify [sic] their thoughts by modifying their behavior.”⁴ In that chapter I also made the distinction made by Jérôme Bel and Xavier Le Roy between dance as involving a “communion” of some sort, while visual artists often Page 192 → work alone.⁵ The artist-collaborator is something that models of conceptual and post-conceptual art generally do not include, possibly assuming the traditional model of sole authorship. However, Australian art theorist Susan Best describes a tradition of critical approaches to authorship within highly conceptual work post 1960s through its depersonalization, not so much through the treatment of a given material, but through a practice of art-making that is socialized and collective.⁶ Closer to Lasica’s creative community and quite different to Hassabi’s sole authorial hand, Gothe-Snape’s process in these explicitly choreographic case studies allows her to work both conceptually and technically, taking risks within the safety of an extended artist community which includes her long-term collaborator, Brian Fuata. Where issues of visibility, scales of economy, and remuneration finally tore through the Rauschenberg–Cage–Cunningham community, Gothe-Snape invests in balancing issues of agency and ownership through an attention to the conditions for her collaborators and the ways in which they are acknowledged. She notes that in her process, collaboration is “interpersonal and emotional”; she is “not just giving the dancer the task”—there are “social, emotional, and then workplace relations.”⁷ Gothe-Snape is acutely aware of the complexities of the dancer’s position in this field of

work and pursues an ethical approach with her dancer peers, speaking candidly about the working conditions and challenges around “authorship, power, intention, and care.”⁸

In Gothe-Snape’s work we see a direct engagement with—even direct address to—the legacy of conceptual art, suggesting a “post”-conceptual condition for her work. Erik Jensen cites some very early works that sharply declare Gothe-Snape’s debt to conceptual art:

At art school, in third year, Agatha wrote ‘For lease’ in huge letters on the wall of the student gallery. It was the last show there. Later she paid an air freight service to deliver eleven plywood letters to an opening, to spell out the words ‘Time poor art.’ She gave the man his fee in front of everyone, after the speeches. ‘I love that work. Still.’⁹

Scaffolding her approach appears to be an extended study or meditation on the concept–material bind that is the legacy of conceptual art. Sol LeWitt’s words echo through her work: as noted in Chapter 6, LeWitt describes how “the idea becomes a machine that makes the art,” drawing the materials toward its purpose which it manifests; “the artist cannot imagine his art, and cannot perceive it until it is complete.”¹⁰ She describes [Page 193](#) → her dual focus as, on the one hand, “truth to materials,” and on the other, to “plan a parameter” which leads to the “playing out of a proposition and what happens in that act.”¹¹ Her collectivized strategies decentralize the work’s *means*, which ranges over bodies, texts, materials, histories, while asserting an authorial vision/proposition that holds the many moving parts to account. The *concepts* traverse discursive fields on micro and macro scales; the artist drills down into the details of the specific context and iteration of each

work, but also telescopes out to nation, art history, gender politics, authorship, and sociality. Gothe-Snape mobilizes her telescopic vision to attend to the flow and transmission of forces, concepts, movements, and materials as they range across galleries, studios, public spaces, domestic spaces, and political discourse; “not art as an object, but as a series of activities, events, sounds, smells, emotions . . .”.¹² She describes the “ephemeral nature” of much of her work and is vigilant in how it is transposed into the gallery context; she asks, “how does something relational, non-material, emotional, or even energetic manifest within the conditions of the gallery?”¹³ In a panel discussion she described how she approached “the temporal duration” of her survey exhibition, *The Outcome is Certain* (2020) at MUMA: “all the elements of choreography are central to what I am doing; entrances, exits, sequencing, staging, energy transfer, syncopation, repetition and difference, delegation, collaboration, instruction, trust, love, tempo, shape, form.”¹⁴ LeWitt’s formulation of *material as idea* is here, but across her practice dancers, dancing, and choreography introduce the corporeal, interpersonal, and emotional via a medium that cannot be easily contained.

Her critical approach to media forms and their materiality is determined by thick research tasks that may lead to the transposition of gesture to vocal score (*Rhetorical Chorus* [2017]), psychology text to verbs transcribed onto a basketball court (*The Scheme Was a Blueprint for Future Development Programs* [2015]), or Robert Hughes’s art theory to an emotional directive (*The Fatal Sure/The National Doubt* [2017]). Here is freedom of materials combined with a process marked by a “trans” method that emphasizes the journey over the product. Gothe-Snape has been emphatic on this point and

in line with LeWitt: “this technology or machine that I’m trying to work through . . . I’m more interested in those processes being put into play and . . . something tonal and acute emerging that is unpredictable.”¹⁵ Critic Julie Ewington refers to the artist’s use of transposition as “displacement,” but it seems more like accumulation despite a certain minimalism in her works as they are presented.¹⁶ Hannah Page 194 → Mathews, co-curator of her 2020 survey, *The Outcome is Certain*, describes Gothe-Snape’s work as “conceptually rigorous and materially ambitious,” and this neatly summarizes the tenor of her verbal cues/notations for works like *Here, an Echo* (2015–2017), which work through materials toward speculations: “verbal sorcery,” “ambience takes on the order of the medium,” “a word is a score for acting.”¹⁷

Her post-conceptuality involves a virtuosic transdisciplinarity (or “a-disciplinarity” to use a term coined by Gothe-Snape and Fuata), which presents multiple media in complex relations.¹⁸ The artist describes her work as “scrambled eggs,” but it actually poses a serious challenge to the whole notion of discipline as it relates to art: “I can’t decide to be more disciplined . . . I think that’s the thing, it’s so much about discipline and I just don’t see any disciplines. I see a field of action and I just want to move in it.”¹⁹ This recalls Robert Morris’s statement in 1971 that emphasizes the artist’s liberty to explore all of their capacities for production in a post-medium mode, and connects Gothe-Snape to the Neo-Dada lineage running this project:

What the hand and arm motion can do in relation to flat surfaces is different from what hand, arm and body can do in relation to objects in three dimensions. Such differences of engagement (and their extensions beyond technological means) amount to different forms of behaviour. In this light the artificiality of media-based distinctions falls away (painting, sculpture, dance, etc.). There are instead some activities that interact with surfaces, some with objects, some with objects and a temporal dimension, etc. To focus on the production end of art and to lift up the entire continuum of the process of making.²⁰

Gothe-Snape's work can appear as site-based installations (*Three Physical Doorways*, *One Conceptual Wedge* and *A Gentle Breeze* [2017], PowerPoint files (*POWERPOINT CATALOGUE* [2008–]), walking tours (*Here, an Echo* [2015–2017]), performances (*Cruising in the MCA* [2010]), multi-screen works (*Five Columns* [2019]), live inscriptions (*Every Artist Remembered* series [2009–2018]), or sculpture (*Living Sculpture [White]* [2013]). One example of this transdisciplinary approach is a Biennale of Sydney Legacy Artwork Project commission to develop a public work, *Here, an Echo*. This took the form of a *project* in the sense of a total work of art made up of multiple events and encounters, including walking the streets guided by her collaborator, choreographer Brooke Stamp, who modelled a [Page 195](#) → certain mode of attention and physical responses to the spaces, and a text-based installation in Wemyss Lane, Surry Hills using phrases discovered throughout the research and stencilled onto the side of buildings and the surface of the road. Her interest in public art, placing works incognito by mimicking the rhetorical devices that surround us (hard courts for sport, signage, bill posters, PowerPoint presentations), puts art into the flow of the

everyday and blurs the line between art and life. Choreography is a central device in crafting the movement this requires, but I now turn to two more explicitly choreographic works: *Rhetorical Chorus* (2017) and the earlier *Three Ways to Enter and Exit* (2011).

Rhetorical Chorus (2017) is a work that includes spoken text performed by The Prologue (Brian Fuata) and The Transmitter (Joan La Barbara), a score sung by a chorus of six, gestural cues/conducting, two choreographer-dancers as The Right Hand and The Left Hand (Lizzie Thomson and Brooke Stamp), found footage, and light–color–text projection, all combined in a proscenium presentation.²¹ The work involves transcribing the hand gestures accompanying conceptual artist Lawrence Weiner’s speech in a video (which is projected during the work as a tight close-up on his hands) to choral vocalizations and choreographed movement. The result is a performance that approaches the condition of painting, or an opera that looks like a slideshow. Watching from halfway up the vast Bay 17 theater in Carriageworks in Sydney, the stage space, back projection, and performers are flattened by blocks of color, written text, and relatively static behaviors by the chorus (walking, crawling, making shapes, standing, crouching) forming compositions that the dancers occasionally cut through quite wildly with their scored improvisations. All of the various elements are following the score, derived from Weiner’s hand gestures, which is pressed through the specific media: dance, song, spoken word, written text, color, and light.²²

Gothe-Snape’s projection of footage of Weiner’s hand gestures, apparently accompanying his (inaudible) description of his art of “pure ideas” that appears elsewhere in the work in spoken and written form, mashes together

the legacy of conceptual art with a choreographic attention to the movements of his hands. In Gothe-Snape's account, it is a visual commentary on Weiner's confident assertion of the conceptual over the material: "I wanted to take the words out of his practice and understand what was left."²³ In this sense, it presents a contradiction at the heart of conceptual art—the corporeal within the conceptual—through an extended portrait of the hands of a sculptor who ultimately chooses text as his medium. Page 196 → Gothe-Snape shows how Weiner inadvertently expresses himself corporeally, beyond his own language-based definitions of his language-based conceptual art. Gothe-Snape is also drawing our attention to the historical figure of an artist who is able to make such definitions and assertions:



Agatha Gothe-Snape, *Rhetorical Chorus*, 2017, performance, choral and choreographic performance score and PowerPoint projection; 70 minutes. Performed at Carriageworks, LIVEWORKS 2017, Sydney, 19–29 October 2017. Originally commissioned by Performa, Performance Space and the Keir Foundation for Performa 15, 1–22 November 2015. Co-presented by Performance Space, MAAS and Carriageworks, Sydney. Photo: Document Photography. Photo courtesy of the artist and The Commercial, Sydney. Performance documentation, dress rehearsal, 19 October 2017.

. . . trying to untangle the gravitas of the twentieth century and therefore the male icon of the twentieth century. I was so accustomed to listening to men talk . . . what are they saying and why do they have so much gravity and how they're using specific tools to quieten you and . . . unravel your own power . . . I took 'rhetorical' as how to lodge an argument that's believable and that is the argument of the twentieth century . . . we believed it with such hope . . . to undo this legacy for me it's important to drill into it . . . until it dissolves this rhetorical force of his argument into something else.²⁴

Weiner's authoritative position and clear concepts are suspended, against his will. His voice is silenced and his gestures transform and proliferatePage 197
→ in multiple iterations across various media that have a life of their own, disassembling the notion of an originary and authoritative gesture. As Amelia Wallen notes, Gothe-Snape "collapsed the protagonist of conceptual art into the ensemble."²⁵ His background as a sculptor is clear to Gothe-Snape who describes how "his hands seemed to be sculpting the space itself—sheering an edge here, moulding a peak there."²⁶ The division between the disciplinary and transdisciplinary, and the material and conceptual in Weiner's approach to his art, is thus challenged by pinpointing the performative, corporeal dimension in the artist's discourse. The prologue text at the opening of the work, spoken by Fuata, is made up of "found fragments of Weiner's utterances ordered alphabetically." Weiner is thus "deviated, detoured and embodied" in the work as a whole, a work that has had various iterations (one of the dancers was severely injured on opening night and the performances went on without her, and there has been an earlier version at *Performa 15*) and multiple authors (Goth-Snape describes giving some decisions and agency over to the composer, Megan Alice Clune, and the choreographer-dancers, and there was also a dramaturg on the project, Sarah Rodigari).²⁷

Gesture and its links to rhetoric, which Gothe-Snape notes "must work in the silence between and around words," form a persistent theme and framing imperative in her work.²⁸ In *Rhetorical Chorus*, the physical gestures of Weiner open a space that his words—and his official artistic gestures that manifest primarily as written text—do not touch upon. The gestural as the medial or processual aspect of action, characterized by

philosopher Giorgio Agamben as “a means without end,” is a touchstone for Gothe-Snape who arrives at a diversity of materials through research and studio practice to then lift out tokens as the remainder and persisting work of art.²⁹ The work-as-process is never far from these tokens, or what Lasica et al. would call “solutions” or “findings” that remind us that dance as contemporary art is not reducible to performances but expands beyond such singular and contingent iterations.³⁰ Associations between gesture, mediality, and the “trans” of transmedial are connected to the artist’s interest in flow as an ideal state; she describes watching the dancers she works with when they are “in flow” during improvisation as being “completely captivating.”³¹ Gothe-Snape tries to keep this sense of flow in her works as a whole by, as noted, emphasizing the procedural but also engaging with improvisational methods. In *Rhetorical Chorus*, where she brought so many media together, Gothe-Snape employed both improvisation and predetermined elements so we could describe an overall use of *gesture as a*
Page 198 → *modality/mediality* that cuts through the overall composition, infuses the whole, and informs each element.³² Here is “means without end” produced through a combination of what LeWitt would call “a machine that makes the art”; as she states, “I don’t really care what it looks like or what it was because I was more interested in the process that had led to it.”³³

In an even more explicitly choreographic work, *Three Ways to Enter and Exit* (2011), three solo dances (by Brooke Stamp, Lizzie Thomson, and Tim Darbyshire) are improvised from three personalized scores by Gothe-Snape in gouache and pencil. These are offered “as totems” and “acts of love” to the three artists with whom she has personal relationships.³⁴ A response to “generations of conceptual art and instructional dance” (the scores are a

cross between 1980s Brophy-style graphics and ballroom dance-style footwork guides), the work asks the dancers to become “complicit with the construction of events and images that make up my work” by translating the scores into movement, dispersing authorship to the point where they “made uncanny or strange my score.”³⁵ In this way, the self-contained action scores of Bruce Nauman or Dan Graham, which often resulted in solo-authored performances for camera, are less relevant than the socialized scoring of La Monte Young or Simone Forti, which has an outward-facing agenda and orientation, is often dedicated to other artists, calls other artists into the performance, and is able to be re-performed by many.

Beyond the generation of new solo dances from Gothe-Snape’s scores, a documentation of *Three Ways to Enter and Exit* reveals another outcome of the work that emerges from the act of translation. It shows Gothe-Snape watching Stamp attending to her score, observing her working with the instruction, watching “the dancer’s virtuosity as material.”³⁶ Dance seems to model a form of *attention* to the art event as a climate or condition (the medial aspects of art), a mode of viewing that Gothe-Snape’s work demands of its audiences; the dancer becomes a guide for their fellow attendees on how to look and respond to Gothe-Snape’s visual art. Reintroducing the body into her art as interlocutor or one medium among many is a key strategy for tackling “the thickness and richness of the intermeshing world” as she experiences it corporeally:

I'm always in a crisis of incorporation with the world, and language cannot always account for that . . . the body [is] at the nexus of the hugely impossible feat of relating to the world . . . I find it incredibly overwhelming and that overwhelming happens in the body [where the] social and interpersonalPage 199
→ is formed . . . it is the kind of thing that's been obliterated from 20th century art (not in all cases and not in a lot of female artist cases).³⁷

The interest in the body extends from Gothe-Snape's own body, through her performers, and on to her audience. *Three Ways to Enter and Exit* seems connected to the artist's project the year before with Brian Fuata, *Cruising in the MCA* (2010), which modelled the kind of attention required for viewing art on the way that members of the gay community attend to public spaces when cruising for sex. This participatory work drew visitors at the 2010 Primavera art show at the Museum of Contemporary Art (MCA) in Sydney into a simple body practice to prepare them for their experience in the gallery; a prescient project that pre-dates (and in many ways exceeds) the broader embrace of participatory strategies in galleries internationally. For Gothe-Snape and Fuata, repeated three times a week for three months, it constituted a physical practice.

Goth-Snape was trained in performance, body techniques, and painting and thus epitomizes the transmedial artist. In Peter Osborne's work on Xavier Le Roy, he points out a problem that could well apply to the critical reception of some of Gothe-Snape's work. In the critical writing on Le Roy's gallery-based work, Osborne warns of a presumption of

a substantial or ‘ontological’ category of dance (at the core of a wider concept of performance) as the medium of the enactment of its own questioning, deconstruction, unravelling, expansion, and transformation . . . a sign of the still-enduring power of the discourse and practices of medium-specific modernism.³⁸

Instead of taking such an approach to Le Roy’s work, Osborne sees the need for a broader critical context: the entire field of contemporary art. Gothe-Snape’s work across several art categories, including graphic art, theater, sculpture, painting, as well as dance, assumes an equity among such media that is adequately represented in her term “a-disciplinary,” and allows the choreographic to break free of the kind of post-disciplinary frameworks that Osborne detects in some current critical approaches to dance and the gallery. In order to adequately frame Gothe-Snape’s work, an understanding of dance knowledges by the critic or theorist should be a part of their critical toolkit and calls for a new kind of commentator. This book project, alongside many others listed in Chapter 1, attempts such a critical position, following the progression of dance and choreography as it Page 200 → emerges as a more central facet of contemporary arts practices. And this progression is nowhere more convincing than in collaborative practices such as Gothe-Snape’s which care for dancer agency and expert knowledges, modelling best practice as part of their realization.³⁹ Gothe-Snape’s interest in the vagaries of art history, which drives a project such as the series *Every Artist Remembered*, may also guide her recalibration of disciplinary hierarchies.⁴⁰ And her sly feminism exposed in her reframing of canonized male art figures such as Weiner and Hughes, the modesty of her multidisciplinary,

or her explicit address to gender inequity in works such as *Trying to Find Comfort in an Uncomfortable Chair* (2019), chimes with the uniquely female profile of contemporary dance lineages.⁴¹

Goth-Snape is inventing new ways of working, approaching each project with a set of concepts (rhetoric, proximity, ambience), materials (a yellow line, Robert Hughes's closing remarks in his *Shock of the New* series, Weiner's hand gestures, action scores, cartography), and strategies that owe much to dance and performance (transposition, improvisation, repetition, witnessing, instruction, attunement alongside her comprehensive list above). She states, "I don't really care what it looks like or what it is, as long as there is a truth to the materials, a deep valuing of the instruction, which might be in struggle, the playing out of a proposition."⁴² She demonstrates a transdisciplinary virtuosity that multiplies possibilities, frameworks, positions, and perspectives, inventing unique spectatorial propositions where a performance looks like a painting, or a basketball court is a mood-reader. Fellow Sydney-based artist Latai Taumoepeau (Case Study 11) is similarly charting new ways of working across media but with a more overtly body-centered practice that moves beyond the corporeal to a consistent set of props (water, sand, tarpaulin, glass) that contextualize her body as one material among an ecology of co-extensive elements. As scholar Talei Lusia Mangioni notes, "Taumoepeau thinks with elements."⁴³ Her commitment to instruction or task sings with Goth-Snape's more explicit citation of conceptual lineages, and Taumoepeau is no less post-conceptual in her conscious engagement of a critical and telescopic position. Both female artists thus operate within and beyond the bounds of current aesthetic frameworks.

While in Part IV Adam Linder, Shelley Lasica, and Maria Hassabi helped establish what we could call dance as a contemporary art medium, Part V launches with Gothe-Snape and concludes with Taumoepeau, framing a chapter that complicates both the notion of choreographic authorship and the contours of the field regarding dance and art history. If Page 201

– conceptual dance and art are still taking shape within historiography, the post-conceptual situation is still emergent, multiplicitous and compelling in its promise of new paradigms and possibilities. One striking feature of recent activity within global contemporary dance that is in dialogue with the broader field of contemporary art is an even more pronounced turn to the materiality of dancers and dancing, building on the resistance within conceptual dance to the dematerializing extremes of conceptual art. So, before turning to Taumoepeau, Chapter 8 starts with a reactionary turn back to the dancing body in recent dance practices and associated theory by some of the central protagonists in the debates surrounding non-dance, recalling mid-century painter and theorist Robert Motherwell’s comment that “perhaps the effort to destroy one medium makes one as sensitive to its qualities as love of it.”⁴⁴

Chapter 8

The Persistence of Dance at the Point of Its Disappearance

8.1 Introduction

Following an apparent meeting ground for dance and visual art in (variations on) the conceptual (in the 1960 and 1970s, and later in the 1990s), a very recent and widespread return to the activity of dancing, which has involved honoring the work of the dancer through a greater understanding of their labor, is understood to be at the heart of the visual arts' renewed interest in dance. The characteristics of Peter Osborne's model of the post-conceptual—art that is transdisciplinary and telescopic, temporally expansive and unhinged from specific iterations, yet deeply self-aware of the contemporaneous context, institutional frames, and its debts to the past—chime with the emergent activity of *dance as a contemporary art medium*, and it is clear how an artist like Agatha Gothe-Snape can be aligned with such art historical work.¹ Other art historical understandings of the contemporary condition of art by Robert Pincus-Witten, Hal Foster, Terry Smith, and Alexander Alberro are inclusive of characteristics shared with contemporary dance as it has been defined, via its elements and principles, in this book.

This brings us to *post-dance* as a moniker for certain creative practices engaged in the ongoing re-invention of dance and choreography in the twenty-first century both in terms of re-location (within the contemporary arts broadly rather than theater) and re-turn (to practices to which it contributed uncredited knowledges), and which can be discussed in relation to the wholesale revision of the contemporary arts as a project that is also ongoing. I will argue that dance as a contemporary art medium is one strand of activity within a post-dance situation and demonstrates continuity with the mid-twentieth-century dance avant-garde (establishedPage 203 → in Chapter 4) as a corollary of being a part of the historical dance–contemporary art exchange. This involves recognizing alternative histories, genealogies, progressive tendencies, and future directions beyond the work under discussion that help fill out the larger profile of dance in its *post* condition.

In 2015, a conference called *POST-DANCE: Beyond the Kinesthetic Experience and Back* took place at MDT (previously Moderna Dansteatern) in Stockholm. Co-convened by Danjel Andersson of MDT, dance and performance theorist André Lepecki, and Gabriel Smeets (then artistic director of Cullberg Ballet), the event treated post-dance as “an open source concept” to be defined by the participants.² Andersson coined the term and suggests that it is the latest development in a genealogy connected to the second-wave New York-based activity.³ If it describes our current condition and has some alignment with “post-conceptual,” then this genealogy sounds right. While the conference was Andersson’s response to new dance work in Stockholm, the key speakers who included Jonathan Burrows, Mette Ingvartsen, Adrian Heathfield, Samlingen collective, Bojana Kunst, and

Mårten Spångberg, ensured the conference was internationally relevant and “the place to be.”⁴ There was something in the term “post-dance” that hit on the contemporary situation.

Spångberg’s and Bojana Cvejić’s contributions to the conference publication voice a change in attitude to “dancey-dance.”⁵ In this sense, the term may reflect a post-*conceptual*-dance position. Cvejić confesses to a secret “relish” in the work of the “few surviving companies” that present choreographies displaying “casual excellence and feel for form,” produced by “a particular regime of work enabled by the money that can pay for repetitions.”⁶ Spångberg still argues for a distinction between dance and choreography, the latter now described as a network of technologies that can be liberated from the medium of the dancing body; dance, in his scheme, is “pure expression” in need of structure.⁷ He argues for the “liberated,” post-disciplinary condition of many dance artists: “what we know is that dance is no longer enough.”⁸ Yet he also defends disciplinary definitions as a way of “figuring out what those liberties really can do for us.”⁹ Finally, he states, “post-dance signals a return of dance and dancing,” linking this position directly to “advocacy.”¹⁰ Such a turnaround seems to reflect the problematic division between “conceptual dance on the one side and the dancey dance, real dance or just dance on the other,” noted by Kunst, which recalls the mind–body division that had been overcome so successfully in contemporary dance and theory.¹¹

Page 204 → Despite this apparent persistence of the legacy of the mind–body binary during the heyday of conceptual dance referred to here by Kunst, attention to the work of dance composition and dramaturgy did not actually

abate in the broader field during the 1990s and early 2000s. In the work of collectives like Sarma in Europe, and publications such as *Movement Research* journal in New York, as well as publications by dance artists on their own processes, writing in material and discipline-specific terms persisted and, in fact, accelerated. Artists such as Mette Ingvartsen and Chrysa Parkinson have taken the lead in a renewed attention to the work of the dancer and dancing through their practice, research, and publications.¹² As noted in Chapter 2, collaborations between theorists and artists have also played an important role in both developing and accounting for the current field, and Cvejić is a part of this activity, too, as we will see. So, in fact, discourses on both conceptual and material approaches to dance not only developed in parallel, but also overlapped.

So why post-dance? And what is the significance regarding the current dance-gallery activity? Jumping back in time, some writing by North American art critic and historian Robert Pincus-Witten in his 1977 book on *post-minimalism* resonates with *post-conceptual*. The final sections of his book address the “conceptual performance” of Vito Acconci, Lynda Benglis, and Scott Burton, among others, but arrives at dance via Marcel Duchamp in the very final section.¹³ Pincus-Witten distinguishes the work of artists such as Bruce Nauman and Robert Morris from performance work dealing with “myth” and “autobiography,” being grounded in what he calls “behaviour” (coincidentally the name of a series of works by Shelley Lasica).¹⁴ This focus on movement in and of itself is then linked to dance, which is described as one option among many in this early post-milieu (naming Yvonne Rainer and Trisha Brown, and also Rauschenberg “as a dancer and stage designer”):

walking as dance, amateur as dancer, another way of painting and sculpting—an alternative. Painting without painting. Sculpture without sculpture. That today we happen to see many dancers performing in ways suggestive of modes of painting or sculpture does not necessarily mean that the dancer is a painter or sculptor . . . Does recent dance come out of painting or sculpture or does sculpture and painting come out of dance?¹⁵

This description could be of the current work that, I am arguing, maintains its reference to a home discipline with its own knowledges and Page 205

–practices, while ranging among the other arts in its post-medium life.

Risking the danger of overstating the impact of radical dance and performance practices on the state of the arts post-conceptually, yet following Pincus-Witten’s conjectures regarding the two-way flow of interdisciplinary influence, this chapter involves speculations regarding the significant contributions of dance to the seismic shifts in the ontological condition of art at the turn of the twenty-first century. (This, in turn, is dependent on arguments I have built regarding the historical exchange between the two art forms.) The role of dance and choreography within this “post” situation can be discerned in many facets of the contemporary arts such as new treatments of space and time through the role of the moving body and its explorations with dance elements such as weight, tone, presence, absence, stillness, duration, and collectivity.

This chapter thus draws visual art theory and dance studies into close dialogue. Part III focused on debates and developments in dance studies regarding the emergence of “conceptual dance” in the 1990s and its links to a renewed proximity between dance and the visual arts. This resulted in the

return of a particular field of practice that had first appeared in the mid-twentieth century, *dance as a contemporary art medium*, as one of its modalities. Chapter 6 looked at the emergence of the conceptual in art history in the 1960s and the role of dance therein as both a contributor to and a distinct instance of the conceptual–material bind that has been understood as separate from the primary historical narrative of conceptual art. I argued for distinct and asynchronous manifestations of conceptualism in dance and visual art that do, however, interweave as influences on the current “post” situation in the arts more broadly. In this chapter, dance and visual art come together as we turn toward a discussion of that current condition of art in the early twenty-first century, which is understood variously as post-disciplinary or post-conceptual. As noted, definitions of these terms by Osborne and others are particularly helpful in pinpointing the choreographic alignments with new paradigms of contemporary art that are opening a space for dance; both a physical place for practice and presentation, and a theoretical space that is inclusive of its knowledges and traditions. This chapter ends with some notes on a bespoke model of *post-dance* (and I take Andersson on his word that this is an open-source term to be adapted for use), which sits close to notions of *expanded dance* but perhaps also touches on something like *para-dance*. It has appeared in the last decade as a distinct field of research, practice, presentation, and emerging theory that cannot be directly matched to visual Page 206 → arts monikers but which is part of a broad field of *experimental intermedial arts* with which it shares certain features.¹⁶ As noted in Chapter 1, the dance and choreography appearing in this field is generally distinct from theater-based dance repertoire, performance art, and experimental theater or contemporary performance, but there are some instances where specific artists move

between such categories as is the case for Meg Stuart, Adam Linder, Maria Hassabi, and Latai Taumoepeau. This chapter ends on a speculative note in keeping with the still emerging shape of the dance–gallery exchange in these early decades of the twenty-first century.

8.2 The Material Genealogy of Dance

The role of dancing, as it appears in recent compelling discussions, promotes the subjective and contingent position of the dancer as a strong counterpoint to *choreography as concept*. Australian dance artist and commentator Rebecca Hilton recently published an article, “DANCERNESS,” in which she observes “how unremarked upon, even unrecognized, dancer knowledge—DANCERNESS, is.”¹⁷ Kunst focuses on the dancer and dancing in her contribution to *POST-DANCE*, describing “the material nature and quality of dancing labour, where dance opens itself as a poetic and sensual force of movement.”¹⁸ She notes how the critique of virtuosity in conceptual dance led to a countering exposure of the role of the dancer and the expansion of the kinds of work they do. This revealed how various aspects not normally considered part of the dancer’s work or labor, from “hanging around” to sharing “process and method,” could be more valuable to their overall practice than, for instance, technical accomplishments.¹⁹ Uncovering the true scope of the work of the dancer has deepened the general understanding of the activity of dancing and the corollary of this is renewed insight into dance as an art form.

This refers us back to the mid-century dance avant-garde where the conceptual work of the North Americans developed in dialogue with the material business of dancing. Sally Gardner quotes dancer Paula Clemens

on this:

At the heart of Judson were dancers, people with a deep empathy for the human body . . . all the formal and emotional reasons why and where a dance takes place, were ultimately rudimentary to the less easily described developments and breakthroughs of the physical movement of dance.²⁰

Page 207 → Such accounts make it apparent that the mid-century dance artists, cited by the recent avant-garde in inconsistent ways, were as invested in researching and deploying disciplinary elements as they were in rejecting what had come before, working with concepts and ideas, and trying on the methods of other art forms. Artists like Yvonne Rainer and Simone Forti embraced the tool kit of dance craft, working with gravity, weight, tone, memory, and stillness in explicit ways to unpack concepts such as minimalism, the pedestrian, singularity, democratization, and radical juxtaposition in ways that challenged the discipline's very foundations.²¹ So, while *composition* has been replaced by *dispositif* in the writings surrounding the third-wave conceptual dance artists, the critique of composition both recently and in the 1960s never reached the extremes of conceptual art described here by Branden Joseph: "investigations into composition as a form of self-referentiality that ends by negating and ultimately annihilating itself."²²

The literature on conceptual dance across the turn of the twenty-first century was, in fact, authored by some of those most committed to maintaining a disciplinary profile for dance through the act of testing its very limits. Cvejić's philosophical project in her 2015 monograph, *Choreographing Problems: Expressive Concepts in European Contemporary Dance and*

Performance, includes close attention to the materiality of dance. Alongside her “commitment to philosophy” discussed in Chapter 4 is her position as an insider, her “dramaturgical experience in making dance and theater,” as well as having accompanied some of her case studies “as a distant observer in the studio or as a passionate attender in the audience.”²³ This might involve access to creative developments, interviewing artists, participating in process, or taking the choreographers’ writings (including scores) into full account.²⁴ Cvejić acknowledges a turn to composition in her case studies and attention to dance elements such as pure presence, a decentralization of vision, along with “weight, colour, motion, rest and attention.”²⁵ The first case study in Cvejić’s book—*Untitled* (2005) by Xavier Le Roy—is described as a disciplinary, almost modernist, reduction of choreography to its barest minimum.²⁶ In Cvejić’s discussion of Eszter Salamon’s *Nvsbl* (2006) there is another return to compositional preoccupations—the work is concerned with visibility, stillness, movement, time, speed, and change.²⁷ And *It’s in the Air* (2007) by Mette Ingvarsen and Jefta van Dinther, is discussed by Cvejić in terms of its treatment of “weight, shape, gravity, direction, rhythm, and flow of the dancing body,” along with questions of dancer agency.²⁸

Page 208 → From this perspective, as French dance commentators Jean-Marc Adolphe and Gérard Mayen note, the moniker “non-dance” for this work can be seen as a misnomer:

Certainly, this attitude calls into question the definition of the commonly held idea of what dance would be. But rather than qualify this attitude in the negative, it is better to question what is now the source and the inscription of the dance, and thus continues to operate stubbornly in its field, while overflowing it.²⁹

Choreographer William Forsythe echoes this sentiment when he notes that his interest in “choreographic objects” as “autonomous expressions of its principles . . . without the body” should serve “to make the organizing principles visibly persist.”³⁰ In the case of *Nowhere and Everywhere at the Same Time No. 2* (2013), described in Chapter 6, hanging pendulums in an installation setting that participants can engage with invite the audience to experience physically for themselves “organizing principles” close to the heart of the discipline: weight, momentum, agility, proprioception, and responsiveness.³¹ Forsythe swaps out the dancer for the participant, the occularcentric for the embodied. *So dance persists, even at its limit, in such work.*

The gallery or museum has had a hand in the current state of affairs vis-à-vis disciplinary assertions of dance. Mark Franko connects the materiality of dance, and the recent associated concept of *choreographic objects* exemplified in *Nowhere and Everywhere at the Same Time No. 2* by Forsythe, to debates surrounding dance and the gallery or museum, specifically regarding re-enactment and museal practices:

If the objectality of choreography still remains to some degree elusive, it is nonetheless true that there is a movement afoot to uncover its materiality rather than its ephemerality. And in respect to this project, which is barely beginning, the concept of the museum, if not its physical and cultural reality, is crucial.³²

This recalls a statement by Robert Rauschenberg: “I learned that a work of art—say, a painting or a piece of sculpture, is an elusive quantity—that is, the fact that it’s concrete makes it elusive. The dance, on the other hand—is really concrete, not elusive at all.”³³ From the perspective of an artist working within the museum or gallery paradigm Franko is describing (that is, exhibitions and collections), the (im)materiality of dance can Page 209 → be seen as relative when compared with the mediated encounter between viewer and artist via an art object. In this comparison, the unmediated, physical presence of the dance artist in the close encounter often provided by gallery-based instantiations of choreography makes it very “concrete” for those experiencing the work.

The material aspect of labor for the dancer is something curator Catherine Wood believes is also part of the art form’s appeal for the gallery or museum. She argues that “visual artists don’t have any disciplinary training now,” referring to the much discussed “deskilling” of artists due to an emphasis on concepts and critical thinking, resulting in a fascination with “the material discipline” of dance.³⁴ This seems dangerously close to reviving a mind–body split, however, as with Sarah Michelson, Adam Linder, and Maria Hassabi, the display of dancers’ labor can indeed be a compositional focus in such work. So, through its transposition from the

stage to the gallery, the material aspects of dance—its physical source, skill, expression, inscription, labor, and discipline—gain a new kind of value that is independent of commodity-based economics and directly result from a post- or a-disciplinary condition. This is dance seeing itself from its outside—from the position of the visual arts. It demonstrates how, as Adolphe and Mayen state, dance continues to “operate stubbornly in its field, while overflowing it,” and that this expanded state is bound to new perspectives born of new positions in relation to the visual arts and its institutions.

In Case Studies 1 to 11, distinct dance elements and principles from Chapters 2 and 7 such as process, mind–body work, presence, collectivity, weight, rhythm, and singularity appear as the template, idea, or concept that is then mobilized across various materials. In line with such an approach, in the work of Gothe-Snape, we saw how the linguistically bound methods of conceptual art are adjusted to accommodate the corporeally bound orders of knowledge at play. As choreographer Jennifer Lacey states, “I believe that the body has access to a way of conceptualizing that differs from the parts of ourselves that construct and process verbal language.” Lacey goes on to poetically articulate this physical–conceptual work:

This modality of thought is concerned not only with instinct and emotion, but also with ontological queries, with theorizing. Through the body there are opportunities to consider and present ideas with a respect to their complexity and seeming contradictions or transgressions . . . their integral knottiness, to show the gloss of the tangle.³⁵

Page 210 → It is this decentering of language-based systems of knowledge and structure in order to remain true to the “gloss of the tangle” at a practical level that underpins the resistant status of dance within the contemporary arts milieu and maintains its status as “deviant” and “unclaimable,” in the words of Jonathan Burrows and David Velasco, respectively.³⁶ The impetus to rein in and control the concept as it is expressed through a work would lead conceptualists such as Kosuth away from working with materials and toward working with pure language to transmit art information. Others such as Richard Serra and Lawrence Weiner (who Gothe-Snape cites) produced lists of verbs, in and of themselves, as art.³⁷ Degrees of slipperiness where the body-as-art-object is concerned lead to degrees of instability and openness, “complexity,” and “contradiction,” in Lacey’s description of the conceptual work of dance. In Chapter 2 where I discussed the importance of *process* in all stages of choreographic work, dance was defined as evasive, unstable, contingent, and changeable. This condition of dance has generally conspired against a reduction to linguistics noted in Chapter 6. As noted in the work of Shelley Lasica, with no language-based equivalent for the work, the choreographies open onto multiple relations with extra-disciplinary material that is expansive and inclusive of other media, contextual parameters, conditions of operation, political resonances, philosophical work, and social imperatives. The work of Latai Taumoepeau demonstrates how the capacity of dance to create open, complex, networked, and telescopic work can be taken in directions that challenge the tools for analysis at hand and point to the future of the dance–visual arts relationship.

8.3 Post-Dance

Regarding the persistence of materiality in the second- and third-wave dance avant-garde, Peter Osborne's definition of the post-conceptual suggests a proximity to emerging understandings of post-dance, although his early writing on the topic excludes choreographic works from his field. One criticism of Osborne's work by Leland de la Durantaye is that it lacked current (not historical) post-conceptual examples to support his thesis, and de la Durantaye offers Tino Sehgal as a possible example to match Osborne's model of contemporaneity-as-medium.³⁸ This may have prompted a text by Osborne on Xavier Le Roy published a year after in 2014.³⁹ Connections between very recent experimental dance and "the Page 211 → eclipse of conceptualism" have also been made by Belgian dance scholar Rudi Laermans, but dance studies has perhaps balked at engaging with the apparent impenetrability of this most recent and esoteric phase in visual arts history.⁴⁰ I mentioned earlier Robert Pincus-Witten's description of a strand of post-Minimalism that was prophetic of the role of dance within the current post-medium situation.

The Persistence of Dance has demonstrated both the challenges and insights made apparent when mapping the development of contemporary dance against equivalent phases in contemporary art.⁴¹ Confronting the influences, confluences, and departures between visual art and contemporary dance is essential for any project attempting to analyze current practices working across these historically determined fields. Throughout this process, it has been demonstrated that dance has played a role in the emergence of various facets of contemporary art, at least since the mid-twentieth century. Osborne's understanding of the post-conceptual condition as the current state of the arts as he sees it emerging since the turn of the twenty-first

century reveals affinities with Andersson's notion of post-dance with which I opened this chapter. Ideas from other theorists such as Alberro, Smith and Pincus-Witten discussed in previous chapters also contribute to what follows.

Osborne states emphatically: "today, 'contemporary art,' critically understood, is a postconceptual art."⁴² Osborne's model exists at the site of the ontological trauma of extreme conceptualism that pressed the limit-features of various art disciplines to their asocial, ungrammatical conclusions. Recent dance bears witness to the subsequent destabilization of disciplinary distinctions and the rise of transdisciplinary activity that telescopes out as a result of intense critical self-reflexivity. It is within this context that we have seen the extra-disciplinary adventures of choreography, including the privileging of philosophy within dance discourse, the interventions into the art form's self-determinations by various institutions' aspirations, and the trickle-down effect to a crisis in pedagogical models.⁴³ *The autonomy of dance as a desired state of the art will not be recovered from this condition.* However, disciplinary specificities are not excluded from Osborne's model of thinking about art's development either; after all, there can be no transdisciplinarity without disciplinarity.⁴⁴ The post-conceptual marks a return to the material dimension of art that seems in step with sentiments in the *Post-Dance* reader and the most recent innovations in contemporary dance. In line with this understanding, the *Post-Dance* publication maps out critical terrain where artists and theoristsPage 212 → blink and shake off the adversarial attitudes of the conceptual period with its opposition to a generic, conservative model of dance, and admit to a rich diversity of dance practices committed to its material conditions.

Osborne summarizes “the critical legacy of conceptual art” as the terms that set the conditions for post-conceptual art which I translate as follows.⁴⁵ First, there is an acknowledgement of the co-dependence of the conceptual and material aspects of any work of art, but with a critical (“anti-aesthetic”) stance informing that relationship. Second, within that criticality, there is absolute freedom regarding the choice of materials for a given project (and this is linked by Osborne directly to the “Duchamp–Cage–Cunningham–Fluxus” genealogy).⁴⁶ Third, he describes an awareness in such work “that the unity of an individual work is comprised not on the basis of its identity with itself in an idealized present,” in aesthetics scholar Lisa Trahair’s words, but is the totality of multiple events and encounters that might constitute a “project.”⁴⁷ And, finally, the result of this multiplicity is an unfolding process across time, “a dynamic interplay between the work’s actual and virtual dimensions that derive from its contextual and historical relations.”⁴⁸

So, the alignment of certain qualities, knowledges, and practices of dance with these conditions becomes clear, hence the interest coming from visual artists in exploring dance and choreography as materials or concepts, or from dance artists re-framing their practice within the spaces, institutions, and discourses of the contemporary arts. The insistence in recent dance on the medium of the moving body even at its conceptual limit, its intermedial adventures with the entire gamut of artistic disciplines and their constitutive elements, its processual capacities, and virtual suspensions as score or embodied memory all articulate to the characteristics of post-contemporary art as described by Osborne. The affinity is particularly clear if we consider Osborne’s point 5: that the post-conceptual artwork is “no longer

identifiable with either a physically unique instantiation or a simple set of reproducible tokens (readymades),” so that “the unity of the work becomes both distributive and malleable.”⁴⁹ Dance has a disciplinary advantage regarding an understanding of the persistence of a work of art across multiple instantiations or moments of material occurrence (the actual and the virtual dimensions of choreography). Choreographic repertoire, by nature, consists of multiple “spatio-temporal sites of instantiation” that constitute the “work”; however, this is traditionally limited to performance outputs. Dance in its contemporary formulation was early to take up an expansion of the work of art to include Page 213 → text-based scores, iterations of the work in-development, and compositional commentary/exposition.⁵⁰

So to return to our question: why post-dance? And what is the significance here regarding the current dance–gallery activity? In addition to the processual nature of choreographic works of art and the challenges this presents to the notion of discrete, archivable, and commodifiable art objects, dance’s inherent openness, unassertiveness, and inclusivity has made it an exemplary transmedial form as noted in the case studies in this book that think across the means, strategies, and affects of multiple art forms within choreographic frameworks (as opposed to multi-arts collaborations). This has occurred in dialogue with a political imperative to promote a disciplinary profile for dance in the face of the powerful and potentially colonizing field of the visual arts. For dance, a disciplinary–interdisciplinary tension ultimately foregrounds the persistence of a material (or aesthetic) dimension in the form of the “ineliminable” dancing body. *The persistence of dance is the persistence of the body of the dancer.* The fact that the dancing body as medium opens onto a plethora of interesting complications

as we saw in Chapter 2 (subject–object, agency–authorship, autonomy–relationality, etc.) has meant a critical stance between the art form and its primary material in the post-conceptual context, and this has become a major feature of recent examples in the field.

In Michelson’s *Devotion Study #1—The American Dancer* (2012), the artist is clearly in dialogue with the ontological crisis in dance but chooses to press through the materiality of the form (dancing) and highlight its disciplinary formulations in what could be described as a post-critical mode (the choreographer, the dancer, labor, the floor, modern dance). The embarrassment about dancing that fuelled the extreme experiments in non-dance in Europe is reversed here as Michelson brings it all back: the choreographer as author, the rigor of choreographic and technical precision (despite using dancers with varying degrees of traditional training), a respect for the modern dance heritage, the invention of new movement vocabularies, complex scenography and staging, and leotards. Alongside these material, disciplinary aspects of the work, Michelson explains that she begins from a place “of not knowing,” as if inventing dance anew with each work by making it “a problem”; that is, she maintains a critical disposition in relation to her medium/materials.⁵¹ Michelson engages in an expanded field of material including music, spoken text, and visual art, and recognizes the specific instantiation of a choreographic work that, for her, has a limited life of iterations, and the processual nature Page 214 → of each work within the oeuvre. Overall, there is a keen—perhaps even primary—awareness of context (the discipline, the venue, the programmer, the dancer).

Post-dance can be seen as an elaboration of the consequences of the project of contemporary dance as it played out in the twentieth century, the period in which it was also born. As I have argued elsewhere, there is a temptation to see dance as an artistic discipline belonging to the twentieth century, with its appearance at the birth of the century marking a break with classical ballet and the twenty-first century witnessing the transformation of dance into something quite unprecedented.⁵² In 2008, Australian dance theorist Sally Gardner wrote, “modern and post-modern dancers’ defining of an autonomous art . . . remains an incomplete project,” suggesting that dance’s aesthetic autonomy was never fully realized.⁵³ In this case, defining dance outside ballet as distinct from other disciplines becomes a failed project of one century—the twentieth.

Or rather, if the limit-features of the discipline were the focus of the second- and third-wave dance avant-garde, the consequences of this are playing out in many and varied ways in the twenty-first century with a new and incontrovertible attitude to those fundamentals that could be called post-critical.⁵⁴ Post-dance is the practical and philosophical condition of dance *post-modern*, *-contemporary*, *-theater*, perhaps even *-choreography*. As a point of no return for the form, it shares with Osborne’s post-conceptual the “function of exceeding a limit in its established form (the aesthetic) in such a way as to render it visible and thereby reinstitute it on new grounds.”⁵⁵ Although contemporary dance has never reached the dematerialized limits of “pure” conceptual art, the rigorous testing (if not absolute superseding) of disciplinary limits in conceptual European dance of the late twentieth- and early twenty-first centuries has brought about a similar visibility and reinstitution of dance and choreography in their material forms. The works

under discussion in this book that test dance within this post-dance condition would thus be, for Osborne, art “that can sustain the signifiers [sic] ‘art’ and ‘contemporary’ in their deepest theoretical senses” due to this very persistence.⁵⁶

The shape of this activity has much in common with the “configuration” described by Alain Badiou and applied to Neo-Dada in *Choreography, Visual Art and Experimental Composition 1950s–1970s*: “an identifiable sequence, initiated by an event, comprising a virtually infinite complex of works . . . minor, ignored, redundant, and so on—that are no less a part of the immanent truth whose being is provided by the artistic configuration.”⁵⁷Page 215 → The work under discussion in this book operates within a post-dance milieu, perhaps initiated by the disciplinary crisis in France that migrated internationally. Dance as a contemporary art medium could be described as a return of the art form to a non-theatrical, intermedial condition that allows it to reach through and beyond its material forms to draw out a sequence or “truth.” That truth also involves networks of discourse, practice, politics, programming, and pedagogy that are global and, at the same time, nowhere in particular, and are only constituted through a recognition of the sequence (which is still emerging). This telescopic approach lines up very neatly with an endemic *post-* situation.

This book project has attempted to locate within such a situation a specific field of practice, and this particular configuration of art works has been grasped through shared pre-occupations and certain characteristics, presented as a global phenomenon as part of the international field of contemporary art. However, Ecuadorian choreographer-theorist Fabián

Barba's coining of "the prejudice of local dance" mentioned in Chapter 1 has the counter-effect of suggesting tighter specificities; communities of practice, corporeal cultures, physical lineages, and geographic habitats.⁵⁸ The global characteristic of contemporary art argued by Terry Smith and others "seems less obvious in the contemporary performing arts where centre and margin still remain much more defined," as academic Frederik Le Roy notes.⁵⁹ Our final case study locates the work of Latai Taumoepeau in very specific geographic, cultural, and political contexts and is part of a global shift that is jettisoning the generic in favor of the specific.

8.4 Conclusion

In summary, the choreographic examples in this book engaging with the contexts, strategies, institutions, and disciplines of visual art are one field within a wider web of overlapping tendencies that together constitute the condition of contemporary art. How can we adequately account for such work in ways that acknowledge both the broader contours of that condition and the distinct profile of work located between contemporary dance and contemporary art? Such work demonstrates various iterations of intermediality, from the gallery take-over of Boris Charmatz's *Musée de la danse* (2009–2018) to Gothe-Snape's theater presentation, *Rhetorical Chorus* (2017), which includes dance as one element in a kind of *Gesamtkunstwerk* or total work of art. In this sense, perhaps naming and claiming are not as Page 216 → helpful here as being specific and precise about what artists are actually doing in this space. However, as I have argued throughout this book, the case studies share a foregrounding of *the materiality of dance*, of *context* and *process*, demonstrating a practical–critical approach to the dance–gallery relationship. If we could describe a

condition of dance that might be specifically *dance as a contemporary art medium*, and which might also be a part of *post-dance* as that coming after the intra-disciplinary business of conceptual dance, we could add the following characteristics to those just mentioned: (1) a focus on materials (both corporeal and expanded) as (largely unstable) concepts; (2) a layering of processual means at all stages of the work; and (3) a foregrounding of context or contingency (as opposed to the primary status of *the show* in theater dance economies). We could add (4) a recognition/reconsideration of the legacies of the twentieth century avant-garde; (5) a new profile for the dancer and dancing as holding specific knowledges and corporeal archives and embodying subject–object agency; (6) an intensified commitment to plurisensoriality and sensation over occularcentricity and language-based experiences, shared through co-presence; and (7) communities of practice beyond the dance studio that exemplify a-disciplinary exchange. As a group, artists working within the configuration of dance as a contemporary art medium also lack any coherence regarding form and style but share a knowing and rigorous orientation to the legacy of extreme disciplinary questioning that has come before them with a new scepticism regarding disciplinary limits. The field is also inclusive in its public profile in comparison to the historical delineations of conceptual dance, representing the true gender, cultural, physical, and neurological diversity of its constituents. All of this is framed by a *para-* position: seeing itself from outside, from the side of contemporary art in its capacious—and colonizing—configuration. However, rather than being absorbed into this larger project’s contours, being neither helpless nor desperately pro-active in its own annexation, dance takes the opportunity to sharpen, finesse, and update its disciplinary profile to better characterize its condition in the twenty-first

century as part of the most progressive activities in the arts in its broadest sense. In this way, the realization of the new condition of *experimental, intermedial contemporary dance* would have been impossible without its deep and historical exchange with the visual arts.

Gothe-Snape pulls together choreographic and visual arts genealogies and theoretical touchstones in her complex work. A post-conceptual artist in so many ways, Gothe-Snape's immersion in an intermedial community, Page 217 → and her cross-training in visual art and performance, exemplifies what she refers to as an *a-disciplinary* approach. In this chapter I have uncovered some threads between art theoretical approaches to the *post-* condition of art and the examples of dance as a contemporary art medium in this book. My final case study, Latai Taumoepeau, introduces a critique of such a methodology and the theoretical apparatus upon which it leans, and gestures toward a newly decentered field of dance as contemporary art that reconfigures artistic and theoretical paradigms that have favoured English-speaking Americans and Europeans.

Case Study 11

Latai Taumoepeau—Dancing Moana, Working with Urgency

Tongan-Australian artist Latai Taumoepeau's work *The Last Resort* (2020) is a live performance and installation co-devised with her relative, Taliu Aloua.¹ Presented on Cockatoo Island in Sydney Harbour, the disused and vast industrial building that housed the work echoed with the sound of the two performers smashing glass bottles with an *ike* (Tongan wooden mallet). As reported by fellow artist Taloi Havini, "visitors could hear the sharp tap of glass breaking from the other side of the gigantic Turbine Hall. The sound of smashing glass alongside an accompanying droning soundtrack created a live, human-induced cacophony."² During the vernissage week of the Biennale of Sydney, Taumoepeau and Aloua slowly and carefully emptied glass bottles out of plastic hessian bags that were stacked around them like a dam and worked them into a sea of sharp shards with their mallets as well as bricks strapped to their feet like Japanese *geta*. In the thirty-minute synchronized dual-screen video that formed part of the installation version, we see the action from long and mid-shot simultaneously.³ Taumoepeau and Aloua don worn, hotel bathrobes branded with logos for "The Last Resort," as well as goggles, a mouth-and-nose mask, and the unwieldy footwear before they get to work on the materials. Their pace is unrushed as they stamp on the sea of broken glass and twist

their feet to grind it down. Aloua looks down, but Taumoepeau occasionally gazes up and around her as if she is observing weather or the surrounding landscape. Aloua strikes at closed bags on the floor or the wall with the mallet, tipping out the broken contents. Taumoepeau rips one of the empty bags and drapes it around her neck like the traditional *lei* of the region. The two workers move close to each other at one point, stamping and grinding
Page 219 → in duet. The enormity of the task is signalled by the piles of bags, the broad sea of glass, and their resigned and exhausted postures.



Latai Taumoepeau, *The Last Resort*, 2020. Performance view for the 22nd Biennale of Sydney (2020), Cockatoo Island. Commissioned by the Biennale of Sydney with generous assistance from the Oranges & Sardines Foundation. Courtesy the artist. Performer / Co-devisor: Taliu Aloua; Lighting Designer: Amber Silk; Soundtrack: James Brown; Costume: Anthony Aitch. Photograph: Zan Wimberley.

The overall scene recalls low-paid, manual laborers working on site and dealing with refuse or recycling. Some associations include the link between glass and its primary material, sand, physical risk and precarity, and futile/incommensurable labor. The poetic manifestation of the work's message is realized through the sandbags that are often used to mitigate against rising water, the shabby hotel robes that evoke a dilapidated island resort, and a landscape converted into a dangerous field of material that cannot be "defused" but which also shimmers like a sea. Papua New Guinean-Australian artist Havini tells Taumoepeau,

when I stood in your work and watched this whole bed of glass glistening with light, it looked to me in many ways like how the light hits the surface and reflects on and through the ocean.⁴

Page 220 → Taumoepeau's Tongan heritage determines the concepts that drive her work, and to this I shall return.⁵ Her *faivā* (performance/temporal practice), like Maria Hassabi's, sits close to performance art but is dependent upon a physical discipline that comes from dance and physical training in many styles and techniques. Taumoepeau is a self-appointed *punake*, which is a Tongan term that refers to "a composer of movement or poetry or music," and has also described herself as "an intercultural, multidisciplinary and intersectional solo artist." However, she describes her primary medium as "movement," which manifests through her body-centered practice.⁶

Curator Beatrice Gralton has noted that Taumoepeau is "an example of an artist who sits quite beautifully at this nexus of performance, visual arts, dance and filmmaking."⁷ However, her moving body is both her primary

material *and* content due to its extension to the territory of her nation and region: “I don’t separate myself, my own personal body from this region, Oceania or the Pacific.”⁸ It has been said that Taumoepeau “mimicked, trained and un-learned dance, in multiple institutions of learning, starting with her village, a suburban church hall, the club and a university.”⁹ She has described how, during her childhood, she would:

. . . travel back and forth to my village in Tonga and it was there that I had an indigenous heritage practise [sic] of dancing in large presentations with my school or with my clan and, of course, obligatory village fundraisers where we do that crazy thing of slapping money on the well-oiled skin of the dancer and whisper amongst each other about the dancer’s genealogy and virginity. I’d return to Sydney and attend ballet, tap, and jazz classes in my neighbourhood church hall which I affectionately refer to as part of my parents’ assimilation plan.¹⁰

In works such as *Repatriate* (2015), *Disaffected* (2016), and *Kumi Fonua aka Portality* 39 (2010 in discussion with Professor Hufanga Dr. Okusitino Mahina) Taumoepeau performed Pacific dance movements, remarkably in *Repatriate* against the pressure of rising water within a human-sized, Perspex box. In this work, which I have seen in its live and screen-based installation versions, Taumoepeau occupied a slightly more-than-human-sized Perspex tank that slowly filled with water. She wore flesh-colored underwear and children’s flotation devices around her arms, legs, and as a ring around her waist. She also wore a long black wig. She describes her role in the work as “a woman who represents an island of some sort,” and

performed a collection of Pacific Island dance moves that she had learned
Page 221 → throughout her life. As the water rose, those movements became
more and more difficult, and she slowly submerged.¹¹



Latai Taumoepeau, *Repatriate I*, Performance view for Liveworks Festival of Experimental Art, Carriageworks, Sydney, 2016. Commissioned by Performance Space. Photo: Alex Davies.

Taumoepeau's choreographic knowledges manifest in her work as both specific dance forms and action-based work that often pitches the body against other materials for symbolic effect, such as her durational work with water and ice. Here she describes the choice to shovel/move ice from one random spot to another in *Ocean Island, Mine!*:

This is the dance of today. This kind of labour work. These are the movement phrases we have today. They aren't always these beautiful abstract hand gestures we have always had. Of course, those will always be beautiful, but these are still abstract and modern. Who are we today?¹²

Taumoepeau deploys the materials, media, and exhibition/presentation format that best serve the content she is working with, and the body in movement holds these things, connecting the parts to the whole.

In keeping with the approach taken in this book, I return to the physical Page 222 → performance of Taumoepeau and Aloua that took the simple act of walking on glass to press the work's themes through its material. Aloua had a pedestrian gait and casual manner, methodically working each section of glass underfoot with a twisting motion from his hip. Taumoepeau's performance emphasized the precarity of walking on broken glass while encumbered by heavy platform shoes and with restricted vision. Like Hassabi, Latai's performance modelled a dancer's mastery of the effects of gravity, balancing carefully on her uneven and shifting surface to support her complex movement choices. She worked with her knees well bent, one arm in the air for balance, and took extended lunges on legs turned awkwardly in or out, which increased the impression of precarity. Her progress was supported by leaning on her *ike* as a prop, or against the wall of sacks. This physical performance embodied her concepts of "fragility," "strength," "resilience," and "adaptation," making her corporeality a metaphor for her island homeland which shares these qualities.¹³

In *The Last Resort*, sitting within a contemporary art Biennale and presented among visual artworks at one of the event's major venues, Taumoepeau brought many of the aesthetic strategies of the neo-avant-garde (Minimalism, Neo-Dada, conceptual) and post-conceptual art (including specifically dance traditions therein), into dialogue with the politically charged content that runs across her entire body of mostly solo works. The particular combination of durational performance, documentation, material installation, sound score, and video work makes *The Last Resort* distinct from her other works which have been either on-site and durational, made for theater, or screen-based.¹⁴ In its composition, it recalls the monumental scale and task-based, single action of the neo-avant-garde, has concepts that are realized through and as the material ("fragility," "strength," "resilience," "adaptation"), and touches on land art in its final state as a glass landscape alongside the ecological imperatives behind the work.

Regarding the post-conceptual, we recall Osborne's definition: "it denotes an art premissed [sic] on the complex historical experience and critical legacy of conceptual art, broadly construed in such a way as to register the fundamental mutation of the ontology of the artwork carried by that legacy."¹⁵ Taumoepeau presents her work within a contemporary art context and self-consciously engages with the conditions conceptual art wrought: the ontological crisis that would see the end of art's autonomy. To repeat: *the autonomy of dance as a desired state of the art will not be recovered from this condition*, and I will return to how this dovetails with Page 223

→ Tongan notions of the co-dependence of the arts. Taumoepeau's work is transdisciplinary and telescopic in nature.¹⁶ It is *trans-* or across multiple art forms through which it creates a whole (dance, performance, sculpture,

video art, yet always with the skilled body at its center), and references multiple socioeconomic formations (manufacturing, tourism, contemporary art, cultural traditions), practices (culturally specific to Tonga and within the performance art tradition), and discourses (ecological studies, Tongan philosophy, theories of embodiment). And it is *telescopic* regarding, first, *genealogies of practice*, second, *acknowledgement of place*, and third, *the connection to her larger body of work*.

Regarding genealogies of practice, alongside the cultural systems of knowledge that inform the work, Taumoepeau's approach to *The Last Resort* is in the tradition of contemporary activist performance work. This can be traced from Yvonne Rainer's protests against the Vietnam War in *Trio A with Flags* (1970), Carolee Schneemann's *Interior Scroll* (1975), and Ana Mendieta's quieter *Silueta* series (1973–1978) in the twentieth century, through to Tehching Hsieh working slightly after those female artists, to more recent work by Indigenous Australian, S.J Norman. As such, her practice also references the history of performance art, including risks to the artist's body in the service of stark political messaging. Turning to acknowledgement of place, Taumoepeau's work is telescopic through her position as "belonging to black Australia," and she places her art in dialogue with local Indigenous and Pacific Rim communities and nations at risk alongside Tonga.¹⁷ She describes how she works on Gadigal land in Sydney, but as first-generation Australian on her mother's side, she spent much time during her childhood in Tonga, and this homeland is directly summoned through the various elements of the work.¹⁸ The venue for *The Last Resort*, Cockatoo Island, is also significant regarding the repression of Australia's First Nations people: a former island prison, it housed some Indigenous

inmates, several of whom died, and was home to a Tent Embassy in 2000.¹⁹ Taumoepeau's work in this place keeps alive the many geographic, political, and cultural resonances of these time–space associations.

Regarding the connection to her larger body of work, *The Last Resort* links to Taumoepeau's performance across a series of works that constitute an ongoing practice, including developments, exchanges, and performances in which she works with consistent materials, corporeal methodologies, and concepts. In these ways, *The Last Resort* realizes the conditions of post-dance by challenging the very ontology of art through exceeding Page 224 – the conditions of autonomy, with no idealized present but with reference to a project that is made up of events, encounters, and activities that overlap and accumulate. The notion that choreography is not reducible to performance, introduced in the work of Shelley Lasica in Case Study 8, is all the more potent here due to the layers of context that framed Taumoepeau and Aloua's corporeal performance on Cockatoo Island. The work is processual, consisting of a durational action that was witnessed and recorded but which connects to Taumoepeau's life work of addressing ecological trauma across geographical and historical terrain, and unfortunately, into the future. This last point regarding the telescopic nature of Taumoepeau's work challenges the terms through which I have been discussing dance as a contemporary art medium.

Taumoepeau has been described by Pacific studies scholar Talei Lusia Mangioni as “one of the most pertinent Oceanian voices on climate change in the Australian art scene today,” adding that “the arts are central to resistance in Pacific movement making.”²⁰ Taumoepeau is an engaged

activist: she was a delegate for the UNF Climate Change Conference COP13 in 2007, is currently working with 350.org on civil acts of disobedience, and engages in community work supporting young writers and media artists. She believes that “art needs to have a function and make a strong statement,” and makes work about “the things that are important to me.”²¹ Her primary subject matter is the impact of rising sea levels due to thermal expansion on the island nations of Moana Oceania (Pacific). Sea levels have risen fifteen centimeters in the last one hundred years, and in Tonga, “6 millimeters per year, which is double the global average.”²² With a projection of a one-to-four-meter rise by the year 2100 based on the current rate of increase (impacted by changes in greenhouse gas emissions), this could result in Tongans becoming “a nation of climate refugees” with up to 43 percent of the population displaced.²³ As Taumoepeau notes, “[Tongans] are already seeing an increase in tsunamis and king tides and dealing with that on a daily basis.”²⁴ In *Repatriate*, Taumoepeau used her body as a metaphor for a Pacific Island as described and the affect it produces is devastating. She speaks of the urgent threat of displacement:

When one comes from an island, there is actually nowhere to go. I think the issue I had with making this work is identifying the worst-case scenario and that being the complete submergence of the islands which also means dispossession, loss of culture, loss of language, urbanisation, and the rise of an underclass. Also [the] people that still live on the islands don't want
Page 225
→ to leave their homes, and when they see how countries like Australia treat asylum seekers and refugees there's no way they want to leave their homes. People have said in the past . . . that they refuse to leave: there's no dignity in that type of exodus.²⁵

The threat is no less than the obliteration of Taumoepeau's homeland due to international apathy.

Mangioni explains the political conditions that shape Taumoepeau's work through the artist's identity with both her island home of Tonga and her status as a first-generation Australian. She makes clear that the ways in which Taumoepeau's work telescopes and networks is thoroughly intertwined with the artist's cultural position:

As the largest and wealthiest member of the Pacific Islands Forum, the Commonwealth of Australia, a violent fiction established on the unceded lands of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples, is lamentably a significant arbiter of political decision making for the region. Vastly distinct from its neighbour Aotearoa/New Zealand, Australia, with its majority-settler public and its government with next to no Pacific representation, lacks a Pacific cultural literacy despite its historical relationship to the Pacific and its growing Pacific Islander population . . . I use the term 'Australian apathy' to refer to the calculated mechanisms of obfuscation and deferral successive Australian governments have used since the 1990s to respond to Pacific leaders' demands for climate-change action.²⁶

Taumoepeau's "physical insertion into a climate-change visual imaginary . . . with her body deployed at the epicenter," is the result of the condition of her body as co-extensive with the site of national trauma: as Mangioni states, "using her body as what she refers to as the 'primary cultural material' of Oceania, [Taumoepeau] seeks to embody an inclusive pan-Oceanian regional identity that is based on resistance."²⁷ She combines

this primary, corporeal material, in a work like *The Last Resort*, with glass and its connection to sand, pollution, injury, sustenance, and recycling in a politicized model of *material as idea*.

Earlier I mentioned how *The Persistence of Dance* has demonstrated both the challenges and insights made apparent when mapping the development of contemporary dance against equivalent phases in contemporary art. But there are other discursive mismatches in the dance–gallery narrative.

Taumoepeau’s art has some connection to the “non-dance” aesthetics^{Page 226} → described in Chapters 4 and 5 in relation to conceptual dance but is more in step with a return to the centrality of the body in recent dance (or post-dance) in the context of a broader material turn in contemporary art described in Chapter 8. If we think about a work like *The Last Resort*, conceptual dance strategies such as simplified performance scenarios, a pre-occupation with presence, and “a deep dialogue with visual arts and with performance art” are clear.²⁸ However, key characteristics such as anti-representation, a critique of visibility and movement, anti-expression, and intense self-reflexivity are at odds with the powerful, embodied activism at the heart of Taumoepeau’s work.

There are also limitations to the applicability of the general conditions of the conceptual and post-conceptual or post-dance to *The Last Resort* and other works by Taumoepeau. This is reflected in the artist’s own meta-critical relationship with Western contemporary art: “art is a construction: the way it exists and the way I am complicit in it is a white people’s thing.”²⁹ She also notes that:

I don't use terms like 'traditional' and 'contemporary' in my practice. I prefer to look at heritage culture as being part of a time that I am still continuing to practice but through other means that are relevant to where I am. So I think all performance that's generated now is contemporary regardless of when it was choreographed or when it was made.³⁰

In this sense, Taumoepeau would consider her work “contemporary” but within a continuity of cultural practice that extends temporally backwards and into the future of the oral culture of the Pacific Islands where disciplinary siloing is less relevant. In this way, and in many others, Taumoepeau's work unravels some of the assumptions that form the foundations of art theory and dance studies as they have been deployed in this book. The provocation that this book both proposes and opposes—that attempted definitions of dance as a discrete art form is a failed project of the twentieth century—becomes redundant in this (re)turn to non-Western models of choreographic practice. After all, dance has always been a product of context: in real time-space, in performance, in corporeal practices situated and complex, in relation to music, visual art, theater, sculpture, *and culture*. Frames for understanding, interpreting, and evaluating in such a situation are at their most contingent, hinted at here in Susan Best's comment: “Contemporary art now points beyond itself, draws in Page 227 other disciplines and often requires extensive contextualisation to make an appropriate evaluation of it.”³¹

Taumoepeau's work explicitly resists co-option by the various post-aesthetics when one considers Osborne's discussion of the temporally expansive nature of post-conceptual work, which is often unhinged from

specific iterations.³² While I have argued for Taumoepeau's work as telescopic and processual, this characteristic of the post-conceptual also speaks to a certain transcendent characteristic of much of the work covered in this book up to now. Pieces by Sarah Michelson, Boris Charmatz, Xavier Le Roy, Hassabi, Lasica, Adam Linder, and Agatha Gothe-Snape circulate nationally and internationally, with each work referencing general conditions that are more or less transferable across nations, venues, and their audiences. They travel across borders and into places and spaces that accommodate the movement of artworks through the provision of a "neutral space" (read "white space") and a common understanding of the (white) canon of contemporary art. While Latai's works have also been presented in international museum and gallery spaces and connect with contemporary genealogies of activist and conceptual art as noted, their concept or idea always calls out to another place, her homeland of Tonga, so the work is not everywhere and nowhere, in Osborne's account of the post-conceptual.³³ It may travel everywhere, but it hails from a very specific cultural context which is essential to its work. Taumoepeau states:

I have a saying, 'The more ancient I am, the more contemporary my work is,' so the way that I make my work is a hundred percent centered around Tongan methodology and systems of knowledge. It's how I make the choices of what I make, but it sits well in a Western construct. It also doesn't have to be *identifiably* Pacific for me. The same body in that work is the same body that gets followed around in shopping malls. So my body reads outside my work as a very specific body from a very specific place.³⁴

Taumoepeau's work also addresses a very specific public, not a generic one. As Mangioni notes, "while Taumoepeau's work is multi-sited in its strong aesthetic appeal to diverse audiences, it is not necessarily for the Pacific community but rather for white people who exist around it."³⁵ Mangioni describes how Taumoepeau stages "ecological crises to invoke affective and emotional responses from Australian audiences" as a call to action and antidote to the apathy Mangioni identifies within Australian Page 228
– politics.³⁶ Taumoepeau is targeting specifically white audiences with a political agenda in mind.

The urgency of Latai's political message gives this content a volume within her work that references beyond the formal terms of the work in an explicit way, an element that has not appeared as overtly in the other case studies presented here. The minimising of blatant external references so dominant in Hassabi's, Lasica's, and Linder's work, or the common limitation of such references to disciplinary genealogies such as in the case studies by Gothe-Snape, Michelson, and Charmatz, is replaced in Taumoepeau's work with an absolute orientation to a specific time-place and its political, environmental, and cultural condition. This aspect of the work is a product of her self-described position within a "minority," and as noted in Chapter 1, it forces us to confront the condition of contemporary art and dance as predominantly white.³⁷ Certain artists' gravitation toward dematerialized and dispersed art since the mid-twentieth century can be seen as an aesthetic strategy that both critiques and renews the market economies of visual art. The juxtaposition of Taumoepeau and Aloua's actions in *The Last Resort* against the overwhelming presence of glass bottles and shards that refuse reduction

back to sand emphasized the fragility of “intangible” cultural practices, knowledges, and behaviors not as an aesthetic choice, but as a reality. As Katerina Teaiwa notes:

In recent years there has been a rapid expansion of climate-change research, journalism and field schools, and scientific adaption and mitigation programs, across Kiribati and other Pacific islands. Few of these consider the precarious status of cultural heritage and knowledge . . . A Pacific song or dance is rarely only an empty form of entertainment—a dance and its accompanying chant may contain centuries of corporeal, social and environmental knowledge reflecting the need for balance between human societies and their natural environments.³⁸

And Taumoepeau scholar Maria White writes, “the disproportional force of her body against a rising sea level or a melting glacier is an aesthetic of power imbalance.”³⁹ Taumoepeau herself states, “what are the things that don’t survive in forced relocation? It is the most intangible cultural practices that don’t survive—the things that are not object-based.”⁴⁰ The circulation of art objects and cultural artefacts will persist well beyond the susceptible, ephemeral resources in Tonga that depend upon community and place, such as dancing.

Conclusion

The methodology chosen for this book has been in dialogue with paradigms of contemporary art and contemporary dance as they have been theorized by mostly Australian, American, and European artists, curators, and theorists. I have argued for dance as a contemporary art, but what is the future of such a

model of contemporary art? The Judson exhibition in 2018 laid bare some difficult facts about American contemporary dance.⁴¹ What had, at the time, seemed like radical, embodied creative practices in relation to a center consisting of male sculptors, Minimalism with a capital “M,” major modern dance companies, and established theater venues, was now the white, middle-class birthplace of developments in dance that would influence decades of more white dance. Recalling David Velasco’s words quoted in Chapter 3, that the contemporary arts canon “never really worked” for dance, there are layers of inclusion and exclusion that complicate the advocacy-driven thrust of this project.⁴² If the alternative status of dance in relation to stable canons/art categories is connected to its responsiveness to specific *contexts* and its emphasis on *process*, the work of an artist like Taumoepeau disrupts the linear trajectories of art historiographies through a powerful co-dependence with the here and now. It is *deeply* contextual and processual, engaging in practices that are wedded to very specific people, places, and cultures. Taumoepeau’s work speaks back to the limitations of contemporary art frameworks and places itself within a redressive wave that has its sights on diversifying accessible and visible art and culture. The critique of the male, white canon expressed in Gothe-Snape’s *Rhetorical Chorus* is part of a broad wave of feminist, queer, indigenous, and neuro-diverse art that is finally displacing the international dominance of the Western patriarchy. If, as art scholar Pamela Zeplin notes, there is an “acute omission of contemporary Pacific art in Australian museums,” this tide is turning.⁴³

Conclusion

Persistent Resistance

I begin to conclude with a quote from UK choreographer Jonathan Burrows cited in Case Study 6 because I think it reflects some important things about the condition of contemporary dance as an art medium when it appears among many others. He is discussing Boris Charmatz's *If Tate Modern was Musée de la danse?* at Tate Modern, London, in 2015:

to somehow keep occupying these spaces that can't be easily identified but live in the body and can be activated anywhere, and as much as we worry that we should be more popular, nevertheless we enjoy this place of privileged deviancy that pulls people in, and has nothing to do with history but is about defiant and intelligent becoming.¹

Burrows is arguing for the specificity of dance as an art of occupation or inhabitation, an art that demands and takes up space, both real and imaginary. When dancing occurs in museums, gallery space becomes dance space as the dancing brings all of its culture with it; the studio, the theater, the nightclub, the training, the applause. Much of the discourse on the encounter between dance and the museum hinges on the distinguishing practical aspects of dance and proceeds by comparison of spatial/venue conditions; show/rehearsal/practice time versus museum time; floors instead of walls; shared spaces with audiences versus discrete spaces; flagship

cultural destinations versus community-embedded dance venues; all of the dancing versus high-art contemporary dance. But at the heart of these discussions is the medium of the dancer as a person. They present in a given work somewhere on the subject–object sliding scale that Xavier Le Roy describes in “Notes on Exhibition Works Involving Live Page 231 → Human Actions Performed in Public”: “we are sometimes more subject than object, and sometimes more object than subject . . . a variable proportion of the two, depending on the circumstances.”² However, at the end of the day, the art form most often consists of living and breathing people performing “live human actions.” In his article, this point leads Le Roy to describe, in detail, the people cost involved in this field of work. Maria Hassabi echoes this when she notes that one of her first questions to curators is regarding the budget, hence the time scale and number of dancers she can work with.³

Through their presence, a singular dancer can evoke the many instances of their “becoming” through their practice and training, and the many other contexts and histories of which they are a product. This recalls Mark Franko’s comparison of the body archive of the dancer and the object-based museum archive cited in Chapter 5: “the wealth of museum collections is productive of extreme poverty whereas the poverty of dance is productive of extreme wealth.”⁴ This inversion of accepted terms (the commodifiable art product versus the immaterial dance) is political and claims something back for dance from comparisons that often describe the art form as deficient. It also resonates with Burrows’s evocation in the above quote of a community that is international in reach but also minor, a status that conditions all of dance’s manifestations.⁵

Burrows underscores the important presencing of dance that actualizes this “wealth” in his use of the Deleuzian term, *becoming*, which philosopher Rosi Braidotti describes as “the affirmation of the positivity of difference, meant as a multiple and constant process of transformation. Teleological order and fixed identities are relinquished in favour of a flux of multiple becoming.”⁶ In much dance and choreography, arguably more than any other art form, distinctions between practice and product are slippery or suspended. As noted in Chapter 2, staying with process (remaining ongoing, contingent, and unstable) is a fundamental characteristic of the art form. This keeps questions alive for audiences encountering dance in new contexts: What is it that we are seeing? Is it art? A person? A practice? A repeatable choreographic work? An exchange? A duet involving me? A collective dance involving everyone in the space? Did they author the movement? The openness of the form, so often discussed in relation to an apparent a priori social function for dance, is actually this non-linear becoming in shared space-time that enlivens and engages audiences and visitors.

But Burrows’s quote is not really about dance in the gallery—it is about *dance*. He speaks from and for the dance community, and paints a picture
Page 232 → of solidarity, knowledges in circulation, agility, mobility, inclusivity, and defiance. Putting dance first, the question must always be asked, is the gallery where *this* dance belongs? This might be a question of affiliation; as Steve Paxton says, his work along with that of many other dance artists “was always related to visual arts,” regardless of where it appeared.⁷ The question of affiliation or intention, mentioned throughout *The Persistence of Dance*, informs the distinction I seek to make in defining

a model of dance as a contemporary art medium. As Hassabi notes, it's a distinct field and it requires some discursive attention and new literacies.⁸ Such a definition will be specific and does not encompass the many and varied occurrences of dancing in the museum or gallery, or cross-disciplinary work that brings dance and visual arts collaborators into dialogue. My definition refers to work that first appeared in earnest in the second-wave dance avant-garde in mid-century North America and has been in a deep relation with the conditions of contemporary art as it has globalized, begun to de-colonize, and ranged across unlimited media, bodies, places, spaces, devices, histories, and cultural specificities. This is not a case of visual art subsuming dance but of an expanded notion of contemporary art that acknowledges the complicity of dance and choreography in its formulation since at least the mid-twentieth century. This might be matched to the concepts of post-dance and a-disciplinarity.

I have thus attempted to define, throughout *The Persistence of Dance*, a specific and still emerging field of creative practice and resulting works. Such a field can be defined by negation as a provocation; however, dance as a contemporary art medium may also present in the following forms in some instances:

NOT revisions of stage-based works for gallery spaces

NOT reworks or remounts of historical choreographies

NOT works made for proscenium theaters located in multi-arts centers

NOT choreographic commissions appearing in public programs to address participatory institutional agendas

NOT scores to be enacted by a hired dancer

NOT video documentations

NOT choreographers responding to permanent collections

NOT aligned with performance art which has its genealogy in painting, sculpture and theater.⁹

Such work sometimes appears in galleries and museums, but can also be site-specific, screen-based, publication-based, or community-based. Page 233

– Some of the most important work in the field takes full account—when relevant—of being sited in contexts designed and traditionally reserved for visual art works, as we have seen in the work of Hassabi, Shelley Lasica, Latai Taumoepeau, and Adam Linder, and historically Trisha Brown and Simone Forti. It expects to be understood and assessed in dialogue with works in other contemporary art media such as painting, sculpture, land art, video art (with which it might also engage directly), and if it addresses its disciplinary affiliations with theater, it does so with the self-reflexivity typical of post-disciplinary art.

One of the important continuities with the mid-century activity in this field is the central role played by critical discourse. As a project, *The Persistence of Dance* began with specific case studies and disciplinary aspects of late twentieth/early twenty-first century art works operating between and across dance and the visual arts. The critical framework emerged in response to the work of the work and engages with various fields of discourse: the *art historical narratives* of major creative developments since the 1950s; *dance analysis* as it has developed since the birth of contemporary dance at the turn of the twentieth century; new *curatorial theory* developing alongside new practices since the 1990s; and both *dance* and *art theory* driven by

scholars and artists that is connected to the conceptual turn in the arts more broadly. The project as a whole models an interdisciplinary critical approach in line with an emerging field of scholarship led by largely female academics conversant in both dance and visual arts theory and practices. What has been attempted both here and in the companion book, *Choreography, Visual Art and Experimental Composition 1950s–1970s*, is a mapping of a genealogy that is of major significance to the current condition of the arts.¹⁰ The scope, methodology, and conclusions of *The Persistence of Dance* have addressed our current, critical point in time at the cusp of a new era for the art form when it is well clear of the disciplinary siloing that characterized much of its public profile in the twentieth century. Having mobilized the two major critical frameworks identified by Hal Foster as shaping recent art theory—“on the one hand, the model of a medium-specific Modernism challenged by an interdisciplinary postmodernism, and, on the other, the model of a historical avant-garde . . . and a neoavant-garde,”—I have also signalled the limits of the same as attention turns to the regional, the culturally specific, and the “local models” that avoid being “paradigmatic,” exemplified in the work of Taumoepeau.¹¹ Overall, it is a project that will hopefully generate rigorous responses, counter-arguments, refinements, and revisions.

The state of play for artists such as Sarah Michelson, Meg Stuart, Page 234
→Lasica, Agatha Gothe-Snape, Linder, Taumoepeau, and Philipp Gehmacher has clearly outstripped both critical discourse and institutional practices. Alongside a continued thickening of critical work on such artists, the most urgent next step is to address the ethical and political aspects of this new field of work that so often interfaces with the museum or gallery as

an institution. This includes processes for commissioning, presenting, archiving, acquiring, and collecting such work. With acquisition of choreographic works by a major gallery now underway, various research projects have emerged which address these issues, including *Precarious Movements: Choreography and the Museum*, involving the University of New South Wales, the Art Gallery of New South Wales (AGNSW), Tate UK, National Gallery of Victoria, and Monash University Museum of Art.¹² This project turns its attention to best practice in light of the new demands that choreographic works are making on institutional systems and processes, working with artists as team members, consultants, workshop leaders, commissioned case studies, and anthology contributors.

Finally, what next for the artists and their creative work? Franko and Burrows note that the value—and values—of dance slip away from commodity-based markets to occupy a truly powerful counter-position of resistance, or “privileged deviancy” in Burrows’s terms.¹³ Franko’s idea is that dance creates its own museum in each instance in dancing bodies, thus constituting an “emancipatory procedure” when relocated to the museum, defying history with what Burrows describes as its “intelligent becoming.”¹⁴ The body of the dancer thus generates these spaces through action, rather than being activated and mastered by the space. Like a lover who is always just out of reach, dance sometimes seems to dangle possibilities under the nose of the institution only to reveal that it not only lacks commitment to the institution, it will take itself into whatever spaces it requires.